

THE ORDER OF THE GILT FRAME

Sparrow,

The Council has received your first fragment. The compass has spoken, and the bearing is true.

Her city lies where the bearing points. She was not royalty, yet she was called an empress. You will know her palace when you see it. The Order built no walls there, but we have filled them.

Even now, she waits behind a gilt frame. The Order placed her where she could be found by those who know how to look.

Seek her, Sparrow. The Order does not summon you to admire.

It will not be enough to find her. You must see what others have missed. The Order will know whether you did.

Go with care. You will not be the only one looking. Others before you have paid dearly for what they saw.

How you are called to the next trial is not your concern. When the time comes, you will know.

The frames do not wait forever, Sparrow. Neither does the light that falls on them.

– The Registrar

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